State empathy in the context of personality assessment through virtual reality and nonverbal items

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Bachelor's Thesis
Year 2025

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ABSTRACT

Psychological assessment is a construct often used in various domains, from the organizational field, to the educational or the clinical one, having strong implications at the level of job performance, of psychotherapy, or of the choices regarding the career path. For this reason, the identification and the understanding of the variables that might influence this process is crucial. The current study had as main objective the analysis of state empathy in the context of personality assessment in two forms – with items that were presented in the virtual reality environment, respectively as illustrations. The focus was on its components and on the relationship between them, but also on the link between each of them with the measured personality facets. The main results showed a higher level of state empathy when measured after the VR assessment, but also a significant relationship between this and empathy as a general trait. When it comes to the interactions with the personality dimensions, the results showed significant and positive correlations with Openness to feelings, Altruism and Self-discipline, and negative with Antagonism. This study makes a valuable contribution to the specialized literature where the relation between state empathy and personality is poorly investigated, especially under the context of virtual reality or non-verbal items.

Key words: state empathy; general trait empathy; personality assessment; virtual reality environment; non-verbal items.